

IM Viruses

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Instant messaging, commonly referred to as IM, is a method of online communication like e-mail. The main difference, as the name suggests, is that IM is instantaneous. Using an IM program—such as MSN Messenger, Windows Messenger, AOL Instant Messenger, Yahoo Messenger, or others—you and a friend can type messages to each other and see the messages almost immediately.

Because IM has become so popular, virus writers are using it to spread malicious programs. Read on to find out how to avoid getting or spreading a virus when you use IM.

Understanding Instant Message Viruses

Like e-mail viruses, instant message viruses are malicious or annoying programs that are designed to travel through IM. In most cases these viruses are spread when a person opens an infected file that was sent in an instant message that appeared to come from a friend.

When unsuspecting people open these files, their computers can become infected with a virus. Because of the virus, their computers may slow down or stop responding, or they may not notice any change at all. However, the virus might have installed a covert program on their computer that could damage software, hardware, or important files, and that may include spyware, which can track information entered on a computer.

A computer infected by a virus may continue to spread the infection by sending copies of the virus to everyone on your IM contact list. A contact list is the collection of IM names (similar to an e-mail address book) that you can store in your IM program.

Five Steps To Help Avoid Instant Message Viruses

As with most threats on the Internet, you can help keep yourself safe by taking basic precautions. If you know how to avoid e-mail